

Trial to paid

Week 7, Lecture 2 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- Nurture during the trial: the touchpoints that change conversion rates
- Four churn categories: diagnosing where drop-off actually happens
- Dunning basics: recovering involuntary churn before it becomes permanent
- First-dollar psychology: what the first paying customer requires that the tenth does not
- LangoBee's specific problem: zero trials entered, not trial-to-paid conversion

Nurture during the trial

Why the trial window is not neutral

A 14-day trial is not 14 days of passive waiting. The default state is churn: the user's daily life pushes out the app unless the app pushes back.

RevenueCat's 2025 benchmark: 82% of trial starts occur on day 0. The user who starts a trial has the highest intent they will ever have at the moment of signup. Every day of silence is a day of decay.

(RevenueCat Research Team, 2025)

The three-email minimum

Three touchpoints that move trial-to-paid rates:

1. **Day 0 welcome:** confirm what they unlocked, show one result (their first comprehension score, word count, video completion). Not a pitch. A mirror.
2. **Day 3-5 value reinforcement:** show what has changed since day 0. "You've tapped 14 words. Here's what knowing them would mean for your comprehension score on this video."
3. **Day 12 expiry warning:** explicit, honest, non-manipulative. "Your trial ends in 2 days. Here's what you would lose."

(Carter, 2024; RevenueCat Research Team, 2025)

What to put in the day-3 email for LangoBee

The day-3 email works when it references a personal data point the user cannot ignore.

For LangoBee: word_lookup_opened is the top product action. By day 3, most activated users have several taps recorded.

Day-3 email hook: "Since you joined, you've looked up [N] words. At your current rate, you'll recognize [X]% more of this [Spanish/French/German] video by next month."

This is not invented. It is a query against the dictionary table. It takes one engineer hour to build.

The four churn categories

Diagnosing where drop-off happens

Not all churn has the same cause. Four categories, four different fixes:

- **Never-activated:** the user started a trial but never reached the product's core value. The fix is onboarding, not conversion copy.
- **Value-not-seen:** the user reached the product but did not see a result that felt worth paying for. The fix is the paywall moment, not the price.
- **Price:** the user saw the value but found the price too high relative to alternatives. The fix is pricing or anchoring.
- **Competitive:** the user found a better option. The fix is product differentiation.

Most early-stage products have a never-activated or value-not-seen problem, not a price problem.

(Rachitsky, 2022)

LangoBee's category

LangoBee has zero trial_started events. The churn is happening before the trial funnel exists.

This is pre-churn, not churn. The category is never-activated at the paywall stage: users are not entering the trial because the credit-card-required gate stops them before they have seen value.

PostHog evidence: word_lookup_opened fires 5,225 times per month from real users. The engagement exists. The funnel entry does not.

(June 2026 snapshot)

Dunning basics

Involuntary churn is recoverable

Dunning is the process of retrying failed payments and notifying users whose card declines. It is a late-funnel problem; LangoBee does not have it yet.

But the setup matters now. RevenueCat and Stripe both have built-in dunning. The defaults are:

- Retry day 1, 3, 7, 14 after failure
- Email on day 1 of failure (Stripe smart retries handle the rest)

An education app that does not set up dunning will lose 10-20% of its paying base per year to involuntary churn alone. (Carter, 2024)

Why to configure it before the first customer

The reason to configure dunning before the first customer: it takes 30 minutes in Stripe settings and is invisible to users until a card fails. Retroactively adding dunning after a customer churns involuntarily does not recover them.

Steps: Stripe Dashboard → Billing → Subscriptions and emails → Manage failed payments.
Enable smart retries. Enable the failed payment notification email. Done.

First-dollar psychology

The first customer is a different problem than the tenth

The first paying customer is not an optimization problem. It is an existence proof.

The tenth customer validates a pattern. The first customer answers whether a human who is not you, who found the product on their own terms, decided it was worth money.

That distinction matters for how you find the first customer. The correct method: direct outreach to the 30-person Discord. Find one person who has activated (tapped words, watched a video). Ask them directly to pay.

(June 2026 snapshot)

What the first dollar changes

Before the first dollar

After the first dollar

- Every pricing decision is theoretical
- WTP surveys give ranges, not commitments
- The trial funnel has never been exercised end-to-end
- You know one human found the price acceptable
- The payment flow has been tested in production
- The MRR number is no longer hypothetical

The first dollar is worth less financially than psychologically. It changes what you know.

"Hard paywalls often convert five times better than freemium models."

David Barnard and Phil Carter (2026)

Why a Hard Paywall Is the Right Answer for Your App (Until It Isn't)

Take-aways

1. Trial nurture is active, not passive. Day-0, day-3, and day-12 touchpoints using personal product data move conversion rates. LangoBee can build the day-3 email from word_lookup_opened counts today.
2. LangoBee's current problem is pre-churn: users never enter the trial funnel. Diagnosing churn categories requires a trial to have started first.
3. Configure dunning in Stripe before the first customer. It takes 30 minutes and recovers 10-20% of involuntary losses.
4. The first dollar is an existence proof. Find it through direct outreach in your Discord, not through funnel optimization.

What's next

- **Section this week:** Audit the live paywall: stranger walk, upgrade trigger map, PostHog funnel diagnosis, one-change recommendation
- **Reading:** "Week 7: Paywall placement and the trial-to-paid funnel" at </c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk07>
- **Week 8 preview:** Unit economics: LTV, CAC, and the \$10K MRR model
- **HW3:** In flight, due week 8